Public Health Colosseum

Admin Guide — Running and Managing the Bot

Server commands, API keys and settings, WhatsApp admin commands

Before you start

Log in to the server over SSH and go to the bot's folder. Every server command below is run from there.

```
cd /root/phc-bot
```

First install on a new server (one command, then answer the questions):

```
curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Maerih/phc-bot/main/install.sh | bash
```

Running the bot

Command	What it does
`./ctl.sh start`	Start everything: checks the server, Docker, settings, builds, database, bot, and shows the QR code if WhatsApp needs pairing. Safe to run any time — it only changes what needs changing.
`./ctl.sh stop`	Stop the bot and the database
`./ctl.sh restart`	Restart the bot (keeps the WhatsApp session)
`./ctl.sh status`	Is it running, and is WhatsApp connected?
`./ctl.sh doctor`	Run every check, including that each API key works. Changes nothing. **Run this first when anything is wrong.**
`./ctl.sh logs`	Watch the live log (Ctrl-C stops watching)
`./ctl.sh update`	Get the latest version from GitHub and restart. Keeps data, settings and session.

WhatsApp connection

Command	What it does
`./ctl.sh pair`	Show the QR code in the terminal. Scan with WhatsApp → Settings → Linked devices → Link a device.
`./ctl.sh reset-session`	Unlink and pair again with a fresh QR code. Use when the bot is connected but does not answer. Data and settings are kept.

The one rule: never run the bot on two machines with the same WhatsApp session — it breaks the session. Moving servers? Pair the new one fresh, then remove the old device in WhatsApp's Linked devices.

API keys and settings

The easy way: answer the questions

```
./ctl.sh setup
./ctl.sh start
```

Setup asks for the admin numbers and every key. Keys are hidden as you type; pressing Enter keeps the current value. Then **`./ctl.sh start`** applies the changes (the bot restarts only if something changed).

Or edit the settings file directly

```
nano .env
./ctl.sh start
```

In nano: change the line, then Ctrl-O, Enter to save, Ctrl-X to exit. Each setting is one line: **`NAME=value`**, no spaces around the **`=`**.

The settings

Setting	What it is for	Where to get it
`ADMIN_NUMBERS`	Admin WhatsApp numbers, country code first, commas between: `254712345678,254798765432`	—
`DEEPSEEK_API_KEY`	The AI: **`.ask`**, AI search, choosing which jobs go out in alerts, and the CV and application assistant (needed for it)	platform.deepseek.com/api_keys
`TAVILY_API_KEY`	Web search for **`.ask`** and the search commands. Also set `WEB_SEARCH_PROVIDER=tavily` (setup does this).	app.tavily.com (free plan)
`JSEARCH_API_KEY`	LinkedIn and other big job sites, searched daily	rapidapi.com → JSearch → free plan
`RELIEFWEB_APPNAME`	ReliefWeb NGO, UN and humanitarian jobs	apidoc.reliefweb.int
`AI_PROVIDER`	**`auto`** (DeepSeek first), **`deepseek`**, **`gemini`**, **`anthropic`** or **`none`**	—
`GEMINI_API_KEY`, `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY`	Optional back-up AIs, used only if DeepSeek has no key	aistudio.google.com, console.anthropic.com
`TRACKER_ENABLED`	**`on`** or **`off`**: the opportunity alerts	—
`TRACKER_INTERVAL_MINUTES`	How often the job sites are checked (default 30)	—
`TIMEZONE`	For the alert schedule and deadlines (default **`Africa/Nairobi`**)	—
`COMMAND_PREFIX`	The character commands start with (default **`.`**)	—

After any change, **`./ctl.sh doctor`** shows each key as working (✓) or what is wrong with it.

Data and safety

Command	What it does
`./ctl.sh backup`	Save the database and WhatsApp session into `backups/`. Keep these files private: they can link a device to your WhatsApp.
`./ctl.sh autostart on`	Start the bot by itself after the server reboots (`off` to undo)
`./ctl.sh use-system-docker`	Move the bot, with its database, onto the server's own Docker. Only when `doctor` says the bot cannot reach the internet.
`./ctl.sh uninstall`	Remove the bot, its image and its **database**. The WhatsApp session is kept. Take a backup first.

Admin commands in WhatsApp

Sent from a number in `ADMIN_NUMBERS`:

Command	What it does
`.alerts on` / `.alerts off`	Opportunity alerts in this chat (group admins can too)
`.alerts`	Status: sites watched, last check, how many opportunities are waiting
`.scan`	Check every opportunity site right now and report what was found
`.pushall`	Send everything waiting into this chat at once, as a list and a spreadsheet
`.alerts interval 3-5`	Gap between alert cards: here a random 3 to 5 minutes; any 1–120
`.alerts pause` / `.alerts resume`	Stop or restart alerts in every chat at once
`.ping`	Is the bot alive?

Bot number switches

All are **off** until you turn them on, with `on` or `off` after the name. They act for the bot's own WhatsApp number.

Command	What it does
`.autoview on`	View contacts' status updates automatically
`.autolike on`	React ♡ to contacts' status updates
`.alwaysonline on`	Show the bot as online all the time
`.recording on`	Show "recording audio..." instead of "typing..." while the bot works on a reply
`.contacts`	Everyone who has messaged the bot, as one contacts file to save on a phone in one tap

Use sparingly. WhatsApp can limit numbers that look automated; `alwaysonline` and `autolike` are the most noticeable. Saving deleted messages is deliberately not offered: members delete messages on purpose.

AI in private chats (personal number)

If the bot runs on your own WhatsApp number, decide when the AI may answer private messages. Commands such as `.cv` always work for everyone; this is only about ordinary messages.

Command	What it does
`.aimode off`	**The default.** Your private messages are yours. The AI answers only someone who starts with an AI command (`.cv`, `.ask`, `.profile`, `.apply`...), and keeps talking with them for 30 minutes after their last message
`.aimode on`	The AI answers every private message
`.aimode`	Which mode is on, and how many conversations are open
`.aimode stop` *(in a chat)*	The AI never answers in that chat; `.aimode start` to undo. In someone else's chat the confirmation goes to your own "Message yourself" chat, not to them
`.stop`	End the AI conversation in this chat right now. Members can use it too

Taking over: as soon as you type in a chat yourself, the AI stops answering there (for 12 hours when the mode is on). Your "Message yourself" chat follows the same rules: start with `.ask` or `.cv` to talk to the AI there, and `.stop` when you are done.

Career assistant

Members chat privately with the bot to build CVs and prepare applications; see the User Guide. It needs `DEEPSEEK_API_KEY`; `TAVILY_API_KEY` lets it find the official application page. CVs are made as PDF and Word files inside the bot's container (it includes a browser for this), stored in the database, and deleted together with the member's profile after 12 months without use or when they send `delete my data`. Email applications are prepared for the member to send; simple online forms are filled only after the member checks a screenshot and replies `confirm`. No mailbox or passwords are stored.

Alert schedule (Nairobi time): Monday 3:00 AM – Friday 1:00 PM, a card every few minutes; Friday 2:00 PM the weekly report and spreadsheet, then the weekend message; nothing at the weekend. Group-management and moderation commands are in the User Guide.

When something is wrong

1. Run `./ctl.sh doctor` and read the lines marked × — each says how to fix it.
2. **Connected but not answering:** `./ctl.sh reset-session`, then scan the QR again.
3. **After installing other software on the server:** `./ctl.sh update`, then `./ctl.sh doctor`.
4. **AI or web answers missing:** `./ctl.sh doctor` shows which key is missing or rejected; add it with `./ctl.sh setup`.
5. **No alerts arriving:** send `.alerts` — check it says ON and something is waiting; remember the weekend pause.
6. **Still stuck:** share the output of `./ctl.sh doctor` and a minute of `./ctl.sh logs`.